

Finishing What They Planted: A Collective Timeline for Mitsue's Forest (Early Draft)

Framing note (read first): This is not a Tokyo/gaikoku group arriving with a plan. It is a guide for how the existing Mitsue forestry structure — landholders, 森林組合, 丹羽製材, Mitsue Kanko, the village office — extends its own work one step at a time. Every stage below builds on structures that already exist (existing cooperative, existing processing center, existing landholder relationships). Nothing here proposes a new authority over the forest. The AI data center is fuel demand at the end of the chain — a customer for wood the collective already knows how to grow, not a reason to change who decides what happens on the mountain.

The goal is not money. Revenue is a side effect that keeps the work funded. The goal stated plainly: finish what the generation who seeded the sugi meant to finish — a forest that supports the people who tend it, not one that just stands there aging, as it has since the 1960s energy transition made it worthless to cut ([totman_goryorin_lumber_industry_notes]) Part A).

いのち — Inochi: the concept underneath every phase

Before the mechanics, the reason. The village's own 百年計画 (100-Year Plan) manuscript — written decades ago by a local author, not by us — opens not with agriculture policy but with a chapter titled simply いのち, "Life." Its argument, plainly stated:

- All life is one interconnected community — humans, forests, mountains, rivers share one root (一即一切, "the one is the all"). A forest is not a resource sitting apart from the people who tend it; it is the same life, expressed differently.
- The plan "begins with nurturing people and ends with nurturing people" (人づくりに始まり人づくりに終る) — infrastructure, income, and technology are downstream of that, never the starting point.
- Its own words on forestry, verbatim in spirit: *"We humans nurture forests, and forests are the wellspring of life — the source of the homeland of life. To protect this homeland of life, to cultivate it, to guard the forests — this is the fundamental purpose of forestry administration, and this is what a regenerative forestry administration must be."*
- And its opening call to action: *"One person alone can do nothing — yet nothing happens unless one person begins."* (一人では何もできない、一人がはじめなければ何もできない)

This is why the timeline below is paced in decades, not quarters, and why every phase asks "does this nurture people and forest together" before it asks "does this produce fuel." The CHP/AI-DC project doesn't introduce a new value system to Mitsue — it inherits one already written down by the generation that planted the sugi, and tries to actually finish it.

An outside echo of the same idea — Homo Sapiens to Homo Curans: the 100-Year Plan's いのち chapter was written independently of, and decades before, current academic sustainability theory — but it lands in the same place. In *Human Flourishing Across Cultures and Disciplines* (Zwitter, ed., Bloomsbury 2026), Ariel Hernandez proposes *Homo Curans* — "the caring human" — as a needed successor to *Homo Economicus*, the efficiency- and gain-optimizing model of human nature that has dominated policy and development thinking. Hernandez's argument, in short: humanness is more fundamentally *caring* than *calculating* — self-care, care for community, ecological care, and care extending to future generations are not soft add-ons to an economic actor, but the actual starting point for how a sustainable society should be built and governed. That reframing — from a species defined by what it can extract and optimize (sapiens as clever calculator) to one defined by what it tends and hands on (curans as caretaker) — is the same shift the 100-Year Plan is making when it puts 人づくり before infrastructure and calls the forest いのちのふるさと (the homeland of life) rather than a resource. Naming both together is useful

for outside audiences: this isn't a purely local or purely spiritual claim, it's a convergence between a Mitsue elder's handwritten manifesto and where international sustainability scholarship has independently arrived.

Why a timeline, and why this shape

Totman's Goryōrin history gives a real, documented case of Japanese sustained-yield forestry going from loss to a 40%-margin, multi-decade income base — proof this is not a novel or foreign idea, it's Meiji-era Japanese practice, done by people who lived with the forest. It also documents the two ways such plans die: a demand spike overriding the plan (1943–47, wartime "special harvesting"), and the plan outliving the reason anyone needed the wood (post-1950, fossil fuels and imports). The timeline below is built to avoid both failure modes — a supply ceiling that never lets short-term demand override long-term forest health, and a demand source (CHP + compute) engineered to last longer than one generation's energy transition.

The 100-Year Plan's own structure backs this pacing directly: it laid out its rebuilding in three deliberate phases — 20 years construction, 30 years construction, 50 years revision — a full century, because it treated forest and village regeneration as a single inochi-scale project, not a fundable-cycle one.

Questions for Kinjo-san

1. When would be a relatively quieter time for Kinjo-san and the team?
 2. During that quieter period, could we arrange for you to meet a 15-year friend of mine who ran a biomass power plant in Mie Prefecture — the same colleague who worked with me on the data center we built in a closed school in Aizu?
 3. Have you and your team had a chance to watch the video from the Tenkawa site visit that San Poisson and I put together?
 4. I still have a number of other questions. Would you prefer to go through them at our next meeting, or should I send them by email — whichever timing works best for you?
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This English version is a translation of the Japanese draft `mitsue_collective_timeline_guide_opening_only_jp.md`, prepared for questions to Kinjo-san.